

Sensitive Data Classification, Handling, and Encryption Standard

Practical district standard for storing, sharing, transmitting, and disposing of sensitive information

OWNER
CTO + Records
Management + Privacy +
HR

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major
incident

POLICY CROSS-REFERENCE

CQB FL

records-retention
schedule

acceptable use

Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

1. Purpose

Ardent ISD classifies information so employees can answer a practical question: **How carefully must I handle this data?** The standard applies to paper and digital information and supplements records-retention, student-records, cybersecurity, and acceptable-use procedures.

2. Classification Levels

Level	Description	Examples	Default handling
Public	Approved for public release	board agendas; published calendar; public website content	Normal public systems
Internal	Routine district information not intended for unrestricted public release	internal procedures; staff directories; draft operational documents	District-approved systems; authenticated access where practical
Confidential	Information protected by law, policy, contract, or legitimate privacy need	student education records; employee personnel records; nonpublic student work; contracts with confidential terms	Access by job need; approved district storage; encrypted transmission; controlled sharing
Restricted / Highly Sensitive	Information whose unauthorized disclosure could create severe identity, safety, legal, or cybersecurity risk	SSNs; government ID numbers; financial account credentials; sensitive health records; authentication secrets; API keys; vulnerability reports; certain security logs/configurations	Strong access controls; encryption; no ordinary email attachments unless protected; strict export limits; enhanced logging; approved transfer methods

Classification does **not** determine records-retention duration. Retention is governed separately by the district's records schedule and legal holds.

3. Handling Matrix

Action	Public	Internal	Confidential	Restricted
Store on district-managed cloud	Yes	Yes	Yes, approved location	Yes, approved restricted location
Store on personal cloud/account	No need; prefer district	No	No	No
Email inside district	Yes	Yes	Minimize attachments; approved sharing preferred	Only using approved protected method
External email	Yes	With business need	Verify recipient; use protected link/encryption	Approved encrypted transfer only
Portable USB/storage	Avoid	Approved if managed	Encrypted only	Encrypted + explicit business need/approval
Local laptop storage	Yes	Managed device	Managed + full-disk encryption	Minimize; managed + encrypted + access controlled
Public generative AI tool	Public information only	Only if approved and nonsensitive	No	No
Print	Yes	Business need	Retrieve immediately; secure disposal	Avoid; if required, controlled custody/shredding

4. Encryption Requirements

Ardent ISD requires encryption appropriate to the data and risk. Examples include:

- full-disk encryption on district-managed laptops that may store Confidential/Restricted information;
- TLS/HTTPS or other approved encryption for data transmitted across untrusted networks;
- encryption for portable storage that contains Confidential/Restricted data;
- approved secure file-transfer methods instead of ordinary email for Restricted data;
- centralized key management for enterprise systems where feasible.

Texas Legal Note on Encryption

Texas Business & Commerce Code §521.002 defines some name-plus-identifier combinations as “sensitive personal information” only when those items are **not encrypted**. However, §521.053's breach definition includes encrypted data if the unauthorized person also has the key needed to decrypt it. Encryption is an important safeguard, but it is not a substitute for incident analysis and legal review.

5. Access Control

- Access is based on job need and least privilege.

- Shared accounts are prohibited unless specifically approved for a technical requirement and compensating controls are documented.
- Privileged accounts are separate from normal day-to-day accounts.
- Access is removed promptly when staff change roles or leave the district.
- Vendor access is time-bounded and reviewed for critical systems.

6. Sharing and Data Minimization

Before sharing Confidential or Restricted information, ask:

1. Does the recipient need this information for an authorized district purpose?
2. Can the same purpose be met with fewer fields or de-identified data?
3. Is the recipient identity verified?
4. Is the transfer method approved for this classification?
5. Is there a contract/DPA or data-sharing agreement when required?
6. Is there a retention/deletion expectation for the recipient?

7. Student Data and Online Services

Texas Education Code Chapter 32 includes protections for “covered information” handled by operators of school-purpose online services and requires reasonable security procedures/practices. FERPA also governs PII from education records. Teachers and staff should not independently create student accounts in unapproved services that collect student PII.

Use Artifact 10 before a new vendor receives protected district data.

8. Generative AI and Sensitive Data

Employees may use district-approved generative AI tools only within the approved data-handling conditions for that tool. Unless a specific district-approved service and agreement permits it, do **not** enter:

- student PII/education records;
- employee PII/personnel information;
- SSNs, financial information, health information;
- passwords, MFA codes, API keys, tokens;
- network diagrams, firewall rules, IP ranges, vulnerability findings;
- incident reports, forensic logs, or cyber-insurance/legal documents;
- vendor-confidential agreements or nonpublic procurement material.

AI-generated cybersecurity or legal advice is a draft for human review, not an authority.

9. Lost Data / Misdelivery / Suspected Disclosure

Report immediately when:

- a message/file was sent to the wrong person;

- a sharing link was made public;
- a device or USB drive is lost;
- a personal account was used to store district data;
- a vendor reports an incident;
- protected information was entered into an unapproved AI or web service.

Do not attempt to conceal or quietly “fix” the event without reporting it. Fast reporting can reduce harm.

10. Secure Disposal

- Follow the district records-retention schedule and legal holds.
- When destruction is authorized, use district-approved secure deletion or physical destruction appropriate to the media.
- Do not donate, recycle, sell, or transfer devices containing district data until sanitization is verified.
- Maintain records of destruction where required.

11. Quick Examples

Scenario	Classification / action
Published school lunch menu	Public
Internal help-desk procedure	Internal
Student grade export	Confidential - district-approved storage and sharing only
HR spreadsheet with employee SSNs	Restricted - minimize export; encrypted controlled transfer; delete when authorized
Firewall vulnerability report	Restricted - security-sensitive; limited distribution
Student names pasted into a public AI chatbot to write parent messages	Prohibited - protected student data must not be entered into unapproved public AI tools
Lost laptop with full-disk encryption	Report immediately; document encryption status/key protection; incident team determines obligations

References

- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Education Code Chapter 32 - Student Information Protection
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Security: K-12 and Higher Education
- U.S. Department of Education - Model Terms of Service for Online Educational Services
- TASB - School Cybersecurity: Texas Requirements